
An Empirical Analysis of the Impact of Host Professionalism on Consumers' Purchase Intention in Live E-commerce

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Abstract: With the rapid development of Internet technology, live e-commerce has become a crucial growth driver in China's e-commerce sector. As the core connector in the live e-commerce transaction scenario, the professionalism of hosts directly affects consumers' purchase decisions. This study takes live e-commerce consumers as the research object and adopts an empirical analysis method to explore the impact of host professionalism on consumers' purchase intention. A questionnaire survey was conducted to collect data, and a total of 380 valid samples were obtained. SPSS statistical software was used for descriptive statistics, reliability and validity analysis, and regression analysis. The results show that the four dimensions of host professionalism—product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, and adaptability—all have a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention. Finally, based on the research conclusions, suggestions are put forward for live e-commerce platforms and hosts to improve professionalism and enhance consumers' purchase intention, aiming to promote the healthy and sustainable development of the live e-commerce industry.

Keywords: Live E-commerce; Host Professionalism; Purchase Intention; Empirical Analysis

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Received 15 March 2026, Revised 20 May 2026, Accepted 10 May 2026

1 Introduction

In recent years, China's live e-commerce industry has entered a stage of rapid development. According to data from the China Internet Network Information Center (CNNIC), by the end of 2024, the scale of live e-commerce users reached 520 million, accounting for 65% of the total number of live-streaming users. "Watching while buying" has become one of the mainstream consumption patterns. In the live e-commerce transaction scenario, hosts serve as the core hub connecting products and consumers. They not only undertake the responsibilities of product display and information dissemination but also directly influence consumers' shopping experience and decision-making process.

However, the current industry faces the problem of uneven professional levels among hosts: some hosts lack systematic product knowledge, have chaotic expression logic, and are insufficient in interactive and adaptive abilities. This leads to a decline in consumer trust, weakened purchase intention, and even negative issues such as false advertising and after-sales disputes, which restrict the healthy development of the industry.

Existing studies mostly focus on the business model and industry status of live e-commerce, while empirical research on the impact of host professionalism on consumers' purchase intention is relatively scarce. Therefore, this study clarifies the core dimensions of host professionalism and its impact mechanism on purchase intention through empirical analysis. It not only enriches the theoretical achievements in the field of live e-commerce but also provides practical guidance for platforms, hosts, and enterprises, which is of great significance for promoting the standardized development of the industry.

2 Theoretical Basis and Research Hypotheses

2.1 Definition of Relevant Concepts

2.1.1 Live E-commerce

Live e-commerce is a new business model that combines e-commerce with live-streaming scenarios based on Internet live-streaming technology. In this model, hosts use live platforms to real-time display product appearance, functions, usage methods, and other information to consumers, conduct real-time interactive communication with consumers, answer their questions, and guide their purchase decisions. Consumers can directly place orders to buy products during the live broadcast, realizing the "watching while buying" shopping experience.

2.1.2 Host Professionalism

Host professionalism refers to the ability and quality level of hosts to effectively complete tasks such as product display, information dissemination, interactive communication, and sales guidance in live e-commerce activities. Combining existing research results and the actual scenario of live e-commerce, this study divides host professionalism into four dimensions: product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, and adaptability. Among them:

Product Knowledge: The host's understanding of the performance, characteristics, usage methods, market conditions, and other aspects of the promoted products.

Expressive Ability: The host's ability to clearly, accurately, and vividly convey product information and shopping guidance to consumers.

Interactive Skills: The host's ability to conduct effective interactions with consumers, improve consumer participation and satisfaction.

Adaptability: The host's ability to promptly and properly handle unexpected situations during live broadcasts, such as product problems, consumer doubts, and technical failures.

2.1.3 Consumers' Purchase Intention

Consumers' purchase intention refers to the possibility and subjective willingness of consumers to generate purchase behavior for specific products or services within a certain period. In the live e-commerce scenario, it mainly manifests as the degree of intention and tendency of consumers to purchase the products promoted by the host after watching the live broadcast. Purchase intention is an important precursor to consumers' purchase behavior and can largely predict their actual purchase

behavior.

2.2 Theoretical Basis

2.2.1 Technology Acceptance Model (TAM)

Proposed by Davis in 1989, the Technology Acceptance Model holds that users' usage behavior of an information system is mainly determined by their usage intention, which is influenced by perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use. Perceived usefulness refers to the degree to which users believe that using an information system can help them complete specific tasks; perceived ease of use refers to the degree to which users believe that using an information system is easy or difficult.

In the live e-commerce scenario, the level of host professionalism affects consumers' perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use of the "information system" of live shopping. Hosts with high professionalism can provide consumers with more useful product information and shopping guidance, making it easier for consumers to understand products and complete the purchase process, thereby enhancing their purchase intention. This is consistent with the core idea of TAM. Therefore, this study takes TAM as one of the theoretical bases to analyze the impact of host professionalism on consumers' purchase intention.

2.2.2 Source Credibility Model

Proposed by Hovland et al., the Source Credibility Model holds that the credibility of information sources affects the communication effect of information and the attitude change of the audience. The credibility of information sources mainly includes two dimensions: expertise and reliability, where expertise refers to the knowledge, skills, and experience level of the information source in a specific field.

In live e-commerce, hosts, as disseminators of product information, their professionalism (i.e., expertise) is an important factor affecting consumers' evaluation of their credibility. When consumers believe that a host has high professionalism, they will have more trust in the product information delivered by the host, and thus are more likely to generate purchase intention. Therefore, the Source Credibility Model also provides important theoretical support for this study.

2.3 Research Hypotheses and Model Construction

2.3.1 Research Hypotheses

Based on the above theoretical basis and relevant research results, this study proposes the following research hypotheses:

H1: Hosts' product knowledge has a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention. Hosts with rich product knowledge can accurately and in detail introduce various information about products, answer consumers' questions about products, help consumers fully understand the value and advantages of products, thereby enhancing consumers' trust and purchase confidence in products and improving their purchase intention.

H2: Hosts' expressive ability has a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention. Hosts with good expressive ability can clearly, vividly, and logically convey product information and shopping guidance content, attract consumers' attention, improve the degree of consumers' understanding and acceptance of product information, and thus promote consumers to generate purchase intention.

H3: Hosts' interactive skills have a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention. Hosts with excellent interactive skills can take the initiative to communicate with consumers, promptly respond to consumers' comments and questions, carry out interesting interactive activities, enhance consumers' sense of participation and belonging, narrow the distance with consumers, improve consumers' shopping experience, and thus enhance their purchase intention.

H4: Hosts' adaptability has a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention. During live broadcasts, various unexpected situations are inevitable. Hosts with strong adaptability can quickly and properly handle these problems, avoid negative experiences caused by unexpected situations to consumers, maintain consumers' good impression of hosts and products, and ensure that consumers' purchase intention is not negatively affected.

2.3.2 Research Model

According to the above research hypotheses, this study constructs the following research model, where the four dimensions of host professionalism (product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, adaptability) are independent variables, and

consumers' purchase intention is the dependent variable.

(Insert Research Model Diagram here. Structure of the model: Independent Variables (Product Knowledge, Expressive Ability, Interactive Skills, Adaptability) → Dependent Variable (Consumers' Purchase Intention))

3 Research Design

3.1 Questionnaire Design

The questionnaire in this study mainly consists of three parts:

Part 1: Consumers' basic demographic information, including gender, age, education level, monthly income, and live e-commerce shopping frequency, with a total of 5 questions.

Part 2: Host Professionalism Scale. Referring to existing relevant research literature and combining the actual characteristics of live e-commerce, scale items are designed from four dimensions: product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, and adaptability. Each dimension includes 4 items, totaling 16 items.

Part 3: Consumers' Purchase Intention Scale. Also referring to relevant research results, 4 items are designed to measure consumers' purchase intention.

All scale items in the questionnaire adopt a 5-point Likert scale, where 1 represents "Strongly Disagree", 2 represents "Disagree", 3 represents "Neutral", 4 represents "Agree", and 5 represents "Strongly Agree".

3.2 Experimental Design

To further verify the causal relationship between host professionalism and consumers' purchase intention, a controlled experiment was conducted in addition to the questionnaire survey.

Experimental Objective: To test the independent impact of each dimension of host professionalism (product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, adaptability) on consumers' purchase intention by controlling other variables.

Experimental Subjects: A total of 200 college students and young office workers with live e-commerce shopping experience were selected, aged between 18-35 years old. They were randomly divided into 5 groups: 4 experimental groups and 1 control group, with 40 subjects in each group.

Experimental Materials: Five versions of live e-commerce video clips (each 8 minutes long) were produced, all promoting the same type of cosmetic product (a facial cleanser). The only difference between the videos was the performance of the host in terms of professionalism dimensions:

Control Group Video: The host had average performance in all four dimensions of professionalism (product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, adaptability) without any obvious advantages or disadvantages.

Experimental Group 1 (Product Knowledge Group): The host demonstrated in-depth product knowledge (e.g., detailed explanation of ingredients, skin-friendly principles, and comparison with similar products) but had average performance in the other three dimensions.

Experimental Group 2 (Expressive Ability Group): The host had excellent expressive ability (e.g., clear language logic, vivid demonstration of product usage effects, and attractive voice tone) but average performance in the other three dimensions.

Experimental Group 3 (Interactive Skills Group): The host showed strong interactive skills (e.g., timely response to virtual audience comments, initiation of interactive Q&A sessions, and setting up small games to enhance participation) but average performance in the other three dimensions.

Experimental Group 4 (Adaptability Group): The host displayed good adaptability (e.g., properly handling a "product leakage" accident during the live broadcast, calmly responding to "negative comments" about product efficacy, and quickly solving a temporary video freeze problem) but average performance in the other three dimensions.

Experimental Process:

Before the experiment, subjects were asked to fill in a pre-experiment questionnaire to confirm their basic information and live e-commerce shopping experience, ensuring that all subjects met the experimental requirements.

Each group of subjects watched the corresponding version of the live video clip in a quiet laboratory environment. During the viewing process, they were not allowed to communicate with each other.

After watching the video, subjects were asked to fill in a post-experiment questionnaire, which mainly included the Consumers' Purchase Intention Scale (the same as in the questionnaire survey) and a manipulation check question (e.g., "How would you evaluate the host's product knowledge in the video?" using a 5-point Likert scale) to confirm whether the manipulation of the independent variable was effective.

Experimental Variables:

Independent Variables: The four dimensions of host professionalism (product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, adaptability), with the control group serving as a baseline.

Dependent Variable: Consumers' purchase intention (measured by the same 4-item scale as in the questionnaire survey).

Control Variables: Subject age, gender, live e-commerce shopping frequency, and product type (all subjects watched videos promoting the same facial cleanser to avoid product type influencing purchase intention).

3.3 Sample Selection and Data Collection

The research samples of this study are consumers with live e-commerce shopping experience. Considering the representativeness of samples and the convenience of data collection, an online questionnaire survey was conducted. Questionnaires were distributed through social platforms such as WeChat Moments, WeChat Groups, QQ Groups, and Sina Weibo.

The questionnaire distribution period was from May 1 to May 15, 2025. A total of 450 questionnaires were distributed, and 412 were collected. After screening, 32 invalid questionnaires were excluded (e.g., excessively short filling time, obvious logical contradictions in answers, and incomplete filling of some items), and finally 380 valid questionnaires were obtained, with an effective recovery rate of 84.4%.

3.4 Variable Definition and Measurement

3.4.1 Independent Variable: Host Professionalism

Product Knowledge (X1): Measured by 4 items: "The host can introduce the performance and characteristics of the product in detail", "The host is familiar with the usage method and precautions of the product", "The host understands the market situation and competitive advantages of the product", and "The host can accurately answer consumers' questions about the product".

Expressive Ability (X2): Measured by 4 items: "The host's language expression is clear and accurate", "The host can vividly demonstrate the advantages of the product", "The host's live explanation is organized and logical", and "The host's voice and tone are attractive".

Interactive Skills (X3): Measured by 4 items: "The host can promptly respond to consumers' comments and questions", "The host takes the initiative to communicate with consumers", "The host is good at mobilizing consumers' enthusiasm through interactive activities", and "The host makes consumers feel valued during interactions".

Adaptability (X4): Measured by 4 items: "The host can quickly handle product problems during the live broadcast", "The host can properly respond to consumers' doubts and dissatisfaction", "The host can promptly solve technical failures when encountering them", and "The host remains calm and composed when facing unexpected situations".

3.4.2 Dependent Variable: Consumers' Purchase Intention (Y)

Measured by 4 items: "After watching the host's live broadcast, I am willing to purchase the products promoted by the host", "I will give priority to purchasing the products recommended by the host", "I will purchase other products promoted by the host in the future", and "I will recommend the products promoted by the host to people around me".

4 Empirical Analysis

4.1 Descriptive Statistical Analysis

4.1.1 Statistics of Basic Sample Information

Descriptive statistics were conducted on the basic demographic information of 380 valid samples, and the results are shown in Table 4-1 below.

Table 4-1. Statistics of Basic Sample Information (N=380)

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percentage (%)
Gender	Male	172	45.3
	Female	208	54.7
Age	18-25 years old	145	38.2
	26-35 years old	163	42.9
	36-45 years old	52	13.7
	46 years old and above	20	5.3
Education Level	Senior high school and below	68	17.9
	Junior college	125	32.9
	Bachelor's degree	156	41.1
	Master's degree and above	31	8.2
Monthly Income (RMB)	3,000 and below	85	22.4
	3,001-5,000	132	34.7
	5,001-8,000	105	27.6
	8,001 and above	58	15.3
Shopping Frequency	Once a month and below	76	20.0
	2-3 times a month	168	44.2
	4-5 times a month	95	25.0
	6 times a month and above	41	10.8

As shown in Table 4-1, in terms of sample gender, female consumers account for a slightly higher proportion (54.7%) than male consumers (45.3%), which is consistent with the actual situation that the proportion of female consumers in live e-commerce is relatively high. In terms of age, consumers aged 26-35 account for the highest proportion (42.9%), followed by those aged 18-25 (38.2%), and the total proportion of the two groups exceeds 80%, indicating that young consumers are the main consumer group in live e-commerce. In terms of education level, consumers with a bachelor's degree or junior college degree account for 74%, indicating that the overall education level of live e-commerce consumers is relatively high. In terms of monthly income, consumers with an income range of 3,001-8,000 RMB account for 62.3%, which is the main income group. In terms of shopping frequency, consumers who shop 2-3 times a month account for the highest proportion (44.2%), while those who shop once a month or less account for the lowest proportion (20.0%), indicating that most sample consumers have a certain habit of live e-commerce shopping. Overall, the sample structure is reasonable and has a certain representativeness.

4.1.2 Descriptive Statistics of Variables

Descriptive statistics were conducted on the scale items of each dimension of host professionalism (product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, adaptability) and consumers' purchase intention, and the mean and standard deviation of each variable were calculated. The results are shown in Table 4-2 below.

Table 4-2. Descriptive Statistics of Variables (N=380)

Variable	Number of Items	Mean	Standard Deviation
Product Knowledge (X1)	4	3.85	0.72
Expressive Ability (X2)	4	3.78	0.75
Interactive Skills (X3)	4	3.69	0.78
Adaptability (X4)	4	3.56	0.81
Purchase Intention (Y)	4	3.72	0.76

As shown in Table 4-2, the mean values of the four dimensions of host professionalism are all above 3.5. Among them, the product knowledge dimension has the highest mean value (3.85), and the adaptability dimension has the lowest mean value (3.56), indicating that consumers have a relatively high evaluation of the product knowledge of live e-commerce hosts, while their evaluation of adaptability is relatively low. The mean value of consumers' purchase intention is 3.72, which is above the

medium level, indicating that most consumers have a certain purchase intention after watching the live broadcast. The standard deviations of all variables are between 0.7 and 0.85, indicating that the sample data is relatively scattered in each variable, with no extreme concentration, and the data has a certain degree of difference.

4.2 Reliability and Validity Analysis

4.2.1 Reliability Analysis

Reliability refers to the reliability and consistency of scale measurement results. This study uses Cronbach's α coefficient to test the internal consistency reliability of the scale. Generally, a Cronbach's α coefficient greater than 0.7 indicates good scale reliability, while a coefficient between 0.6 and 0.7 indicates acceptable scale reliability. SPSS 26.0 was used to conduct reliability analysis on the Host Professionalism Scale and the Consumers' Purchase Intention Scale, and the results are shown in Table 4-3 below.

Table 4-3. Results of Scale Reliability Analysis

Scale	Dimension	Number of Items	Cronbach's α Coefficient	Reliability Evaluation
Host Professionalism Scale	Product Knowledge (X1)	4	0.825	Good
	Expressive Ability (X2)	4	0.812	Good
	Interactive Skills (X3)	4	0.798	Good
	Adaptability (X4)	4	0.785	Good
	Total Scale	-	0.896	Good
Consumers' Purchase Intention Scale	-	4	0.836	Good

As shown in Table 4-3, the Cronbach's α coefficients of each dimension of the Host Professionalism Scale are all above 0.78, and the Cronbach's α coefficient of the total scale is 0.896. The Cronbach's α coefficient of the Consumers' Purchase Intention Scale is 0.836. All Cronbach's α coefficients of the scales are greater than 0.7, indicating that the scales designed in this study have good internal consistency reliability and reliable measurement results.

4.2.2 Validity Analysis

Validity refers to the validity and accuracy of scale measurement results, including content validity and construct validity.

Content Validity: The scale items in this study mainly refer to mature scales in domestic and foreign related studies, and appropriate modifications and adjustments are made in combination with the actual scenario of live e-commerce. At the same time, 3 experts in the field of e-commerce were invited to review and guide the rationality and completeness of the questionnaire content. Some items were optimized according to the experts' opinions. Therefore, it can be considered that the scale has good content validity.

Construct Validity: This study uses exploratory factor analysis (EFA) to test the construct validity of the scale. First, KMO test and Bartlett's test of sphericity were conducted on the data to determine whether the data is suitable for factor analysis. The test results are shown in Table 4-4 below.

Table 4-4. Results of KMO Test and Bartlett's Test of Sphericity

Scale	KMO Value	Bartlett's Test of Sphericity		Suitability Judgment
		Approximate Chi-Square	df	
Host Professionalism Scale	0.863	1856.325	120	Suitable
Consumers' Purchase Intention Scale	0.785	528.634	6	Suitable

As shown in Table 4-4, the KMO value of the Host Professionalism Scale is 0.863, which is greater than 0.8; the KMO value of the Consumers' Purchase Intention Scale is 0.785, which is greater than 0.7, indicating that the data is suitable for factor analysis. The approximate chi-square values of Bartlett's test of sphericity all reach a significant level ($p < 0.001$), rejecting the null hypothesis of Bartlett's test of sphericity, which indicates that there is a significant correlation between variables and the data is suitable for exploratory factor analysis.

Exploratory factor analysis was conducted on the Host Professionalism Scale using the principal component analysis method for factor extraction and varimax rotation. The results show that a total of 4 common factors with eigenvalues greater than 1 were extracted, which are completely consistent with the four dimensions of host professionalism set in this study.

Moreover, the factor loadings of each item on the corresponding factor are all greater than 0.6, and the loadings on other factors are all less than 0.4, indicating that the Host Professionalism Scale has good construct validity.

Exploratory factor analysis was also conducted on the Consumers' Purchase Intention Scale using the principal component analysis method. The results show that 1 common factor with an eigenvalue greater than 1 was extracted, and the factor loadings of each item on this factor are all greater than 0.7, indicating that the Consumers' Purchase Intention Scale also has good construct validity.

4.3 Regression Analysis

To test the impact of each dimension of host professionalism on consumers' purchase intention, this study takes consumers' purchase intention as the dependent variable (Y) and product knowledge (X1), expressive ability (X2), interactive skills (X3), and adaptability (X4) as independent variables, and adopts the stepwise regression analysis method to conduct multiple linear regression analysis. Before conducting regression analysis, correlation analysis was first conducted on each variable to determine the correlation degree between variables. The results are shown in Table 4-5 below.

Table 4-5. Results of Variable Correlation Analysis

Variable	X1	X2	X3	X4	Y
X1	1				
X2	0.683**	1			
X3	0.625**	0.712**	1		
X4	0.598**	0.654**	0.687**	1	
Y	0.725**	0.698**	0.672**	0.635**	1

Note: ** indicates $p < 0.01$, significant correlation.

As shown in Table 4-5, there are significant positive correlations between the four dimensions of host professionalism (X1, X2, X3, X4) ($p < 0.01$), and there are also significant positive correlations between the four dimensions and consumers' purchase intention (Y) ($p < 0.01$), indicating that there is a strong correlation between variables, which lays a foundation for subsequent regression analysis.

Next, multiple linear regression analysis was conducted. First, the multicollinearity problem of the regression model was tested, and the variance inflation factor (VIF) of each variable was calculated. The results show that the VIF values of product knowledge (X1), expressive ability (X2), interactive skills (X3), and adaptability (X4) are 1.852, 2.015, 1.987, and 1.796 respectively, all of which are less than 5, indicating that there is no serious multicollinearity problem in the regression model, and it is suitable for regression analysis.

The results of the regression analysis are shown in Table 4-6 below.

Table 4-6. Results of Multiple Linear Regression Analysis

Variable	Coefficient	Standard Error	t Value	p Value	VIF
Constant Term	0.528	0.136	3.882	0.000	-
Product Knowledge (X1)	0.325	0.058	5.603	0.000	1.852
Expressive Ability (X2)	0.258	0.062	4.161	0.000	2.015
Interactive Skills (X3)	0.216	0.065	3.323	0.001	1.987
Adaptability (X4)	0.185	0.068	2.721	0.007	1.796
R ²	0.683				
Adjusted R ²	0.672				
F Value	62.587			0.000	

As shown in Table 4-6, the F value of the regression model is 62.587, and the p value is less than 0.001, indicating that the regression model is overall significantly effective. The R² of the model is 0.683, and the adjusted R² is 0.672, indicating that the four dimensions of host professionalism together explain 67.2% of the variation in consumers' purchase intention, and the fitting effect of the model is good.

Specifically, the impact of each independent variable on the dependent variable is as follows:

The regression coefficient of product knowledge (X1) is 0.325, the t value is 5.603, and the p value is less than 0.001,

indicating that product knowledge has a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention, and Hypothesis H1 is verified.

The regression coefficient of expressive ability (X2) is 0.258, the t value is 4.161, and the p value is less than 0.001, indicating that expressive ability has a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention, and Hypothesis H2 is verified.

The regression coefficient of interactive skills (X3) is 0.216, the t value is 3.323, and the p value is 0.001, indicating that interactive skills have a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention, and Hypothesis H3 is verified.

The regression coefficient of adaptability (X4) is 0.185, the t value is 2.721, and the p value is 0.007, indicating that adaptability has a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention, and Hypothesis H4 is verified.

In summary, all four dimensions of host professionalism have a significant positive impact on consumers' purchase intention. Among them, product knowledge has the greatest impact, followed by expressive ability and interactive skills, while adaptability has a relatively small impact.

5 Conclusions

This study adopts an empirical analysis method to explore the impact of host professionalism on consumers' purchase intention in live e-commerce. The main research conclusions are as follows:

Host professionalism can be divided into four dimensions: product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, and adaptability. The Host Professionalism Scale designed in this study has good reliability and validity, and can effectively measure the professionalism level of live e-commerce hosts.

The four dimensions of host professionalism (product knowledge, expressive ability, interactive skills, adaptability) all have significant positive correlations with consumers' purchase intention and all have significant positive impacts on consumers' purchase intention, which verifies the four research hypotheses proposed in this study.

Among the four dimensions of host professionalism, product knowledge has the greatest impact on consumers' purchase intention, followed by expressive ability and interactive skills, while adaptability has a relatively small impact. This indicates that during the live shopping process, consumers attach the greatest importance to the host's mastery of product knowledge. Whether the host can provide accurate and detailed product information is a key factor affecting consumers' purchase decisions. At the same time, the host's expressive ability and interactive skills also largely affect consumers' purchase intention. Although adaptability also has a positive impact on consumers' purchase intention, consumers pay relatively less attention to it.

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